



△ No rush

Deciding who to come out to, and when, should be based on whether a teen feels ready.

Making the decision

Coming out to friends and family is a big and brave step to take. Most people choose to share their gender or sexual identity when they feel loved and supported. Confiding in supportive people is normally a positive experience for most LGBTQ+ individuals, as it can lead to more honest, open relationships and create a network of support.

Not everyone who identifies as LGBTQ+ has to come out, however. The decision to do so is completely personal. If someone prefers not to come out, perhaps because they face homophobia at home, in the workplace, or at school, that decision should be respected.

A lifelong experience

Most people think of coming out as something that happens once—when someone first tells their family or friends that they are LGBTQ+. In reality, most people who identify as LGBTQ+ often keep coming out throughout their lives—for example, to new friends or partners. Identifying out loud as LGBTQ+ can be intimidating, but telling new people does get easier with practice.



◁ It gets better

Having the support of friends and family makes coming out to others easier.

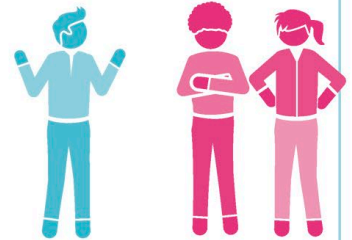
TEEN HINTS

Tough situations

People who identify as LGBTQ+ are likely at some point to encounter someone who is rude, or who gossips about them in order to be hurtful. This is usually because that person is ignorant or scared, but knowing that doesn't make it any easier. If you need to walk away to ensure your physical safety, then do that. It's not worth ending up in a confrontation or getting hurt.

▷ Take care

Choosing whether to ignore upsetting behavior or argue back can be a tough choice in the moment.



Supporting a friend or family member

Accepting someone's sexual or gender identity allows an existing relationship to grow. At an unsettling time, an anxious teen needs the love and support of those closest to them.

▷ Love and care

A teen sharing their sexual or gender identity is likely to feel vulnerable, and will need support.



GOOD TO KNOW

How to help

- Listen carefully to their experiences and show interest, but let them tell you more in their own time.
- Ask them what you can do to help and support them.
- Find out who else knows and if they want you to keep it private.
- Help them find supportive communities, online and in person.
- Be an ally by standing up for LGBTQ+ people if you hear others talking or behaving negatively about people with diverse sexual and gender identities.